

Gray Dogwood

Cornus racemosa

Northern Swamp Dogwood



QUALITIES

A clonal native shrub forming dense colonies 6 to 10 feet tall and equally wide. Slender gray-brown stems hold narrow oval leaves that turn dusty purple-red in autumn. Flat-topped clusters of small white flowers in early summer mature to chalk-white berries on bright red pedicels — one of the most striking fall combinations in the Minnesota landscape. Birds typically strip the fruit within a week or two; the red pedicels persist into winter as decorative accents.

CARE

Adaptable to nearly any soil except deep sand or saturated wetland. Full sun gives best fruit set; tolerates part shade. Suckers slowly to form thickets — a feature, not a bug, in informal native plantings, but in formal beds you may want a root barrier or annual sucker pruning. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Disease- and pest-free. No regular feeding or watering needed once established.

HISTORY

Gray dogwood was used by several Indigenous peoples for tool handles, basket rims, and arrows; the straight, flexible young stems take a clean shave. Colonial herbalists pressed bark and root for a quinine substitute (it's a relative of the medicinal *Cornus florida*). In Minnesota's prairie-forest border ecosystem, it filled the role of "thicket maker" — providing the dense shrubbery that separated savanna openings from closed woodland.

REASON TO BE

Gray dogwood is the workhorse of bird-supporting shrub plantings. Its berries feed at least 98 documented bird species, including Brown Thrashers, Wood Thrushes, Catbirds, and migrating Warblers. The dense thicket form provides nesting cover for ground-nesting and shrub-nesting birds. As a fast-establishing native, it serves as a placeholder while slower-growing trees like oak mature; in larger restoration projects it forms the ecological scaffolding under which an oak savanna or edge habitat assembles itself.